



EBERHARD KARLS UNIVERSITY OF TÜBINGEN

P0326 – Political Economy of European Integration

Winter Semester 2024/25

Title of the paper:

“Green Growth, Grey Justice: The Social Blind Spots of the European Green Deal”

Word count: 5,820 (excl. references)

Date of submission: March 4, 2025

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“Green Growth, Grey Justice: The Social Blind Spots of the European Green Deal”

“.....the work is going well, but it looks like it might be the end of the world” ~ F. Sherwood Rowland from (Sikora, 2020)

Introduction

The European Green Deal (EGD) is anchored in legal order, building solidarity among member states, achieving climate ambition without compromising economic goals – all envisioned to be implemented through effective and efficient horizontal as well as institutional frameworks (Laurent, 2020; Sikora, 2020). However, the mitigation policies introduced serve some social groups more than others and threaten to exacerbate inequalities faced by the most precarious groups (Akgüç & Arabadjieva, 2024). Considering the growing discussions surrounding whether the deal is green or grey, efforts to address these challenges have merely been outlined in two linear axes: financial and environmental sustainability (with a particular focus on its economic potential). First within the financial challenge, the cost of achieving EGD’s ambitious target is high, thus the financialized economy focuses on short term but maximizing growth effects even at the cost of growing social inequalities and environmental disbalances (Ahlström & Monciardini, 2022). The European Commission (EC), post pandemic committed a €750-billion investment package for renovation, green and just transition efforts but most of them are only aimed at being spent on recovery and resilience with an intrinsic economic tie rather than elevating social risks (Ahlström & Monciardini, 2022). Second, within the sustainability dimension, reaching EGD’s climate targets need commitment from all 27 member states, but support and interest vary, as a

result the commission has put a greater emphasis and effort in achieving unanimity either through policy mixes or packages aimed at stabilizing differing interests of actors and that of member states ([Skjærseth, 2021](#)).

This posits us to speculate that EGD is mostly committed to financial and geo-political de-risking to fulfill climate mitigation ambitions, however there is an inherent lack of political will to limit rising social risks. The question then remains in the exploration of why social de-risking in EGD is sidelined and how its linear focus on achieving climate change mitigation through green growth exacerbates associated social risks. In efforts to answer the question the paper first draws insights through the lens of Liberal Intergovernmentalism theory (LI) where limited substantial bargaining and role of powerful actors with economic growth mindset can provide explanations to why social de-risking is sidelined ([Moravcsik & Schimmelfennig, 2019](#)). Its priority in negotiation and multi-level bargaining is constrained since the immediate payoff for addressing social hazards is less than that of economic interests. The study shows that policies to attract green investments and protection of competitive industries from financial risks take precedence over neutralizing social risks. This trend has led to the development of an institutionalized system of resource extraction that imposes significant social and environmental costs on marginalized communities. The phenomenon has sparked a growing awareness of issues like ‘environmental justice’, ‘environmental racism’ and ‘green sacrificial zones’ ([O'Donnell, 2024](#)). As LI theory fails to explicitly explain externalization, EGD can be viewed as a pro-growth stance theorizing that it has its origins in colonial and capitalist ecology, therefore strengthening resource imperialism in the global south.

The paper's primary argument is to emphasize the failure of EGD's approach to sufficiently address or even adequately recognize the social perils inherent in the green transition – such as the effect on the precarious groups, trickling down of the cost to the poorest and the exploitation of resources outside the EU region. By only prioritizing macroeconomic metrics and or stability, the Green Deal not only obscures these social vulnerabilities but also exacerbates them, potentially undermining the very just transition it aims to promote. In the next sections, the paper first describes the origins, core elements and designs of the EGD. Next, it explores three ways that contribute the tendency to overlook social risks—ultimately exacerbating them: 1) *In Perception: economic and technological competition as social fixes*, this section analyses EGD's reliance on market mechanisms, industrial competition and tech-innovation to solve social inequalities rather than investing in structural transformation. 2) *In Practice: EGD as growth continuity, not transformation*, this section explores green growth discourse and traces its similarities in the working of EGD, making it an average growth policy rather than a revolutionary one that aspires to delimit social risks. 3) *In Communication: moral justifications for burden-shifting*, this section looks into the shifting of ecological burdens onto vulnerable populations and critiques the disconnect between EU climate protection rhetoric vs reality. To examine these issues, the paper analyzes scholarly publications, opinion pieces, press releases and communications related to EGD and concludes by proposing future research in strengthening EGD from the perspective of social de-risking and or what policies can be improved.

EGD: Origins, core elements and design

EGD aims to separate economic growth from resource usage, to make EU's economy equitable, competitive, sustainable, resource-efficient, and low-carbon. But it also frames environmental challenges as opportunities across various policy arenas to expedite its pursuit of climate neutrality and become the first continent to do so (Hafner & Raimondi, 2020; [da Silva Hyldmo et al., 2024](#)). EGD is commendable for breaking the ecological passiveness of the previous EU growth plans and for reinforcing its commitment to climate change on the international scene (Laurent, 2020). EGD's guidelines call for a 50–55% reduction by 2030 (in contrast to 1990s levels) and achieve zero carbon emissions by 2050. Energy efficiency, decarbonization, just transformation, and effective climate diplomacy have been identified as its top priorities. One of the problems EGD faces is the commitment from member states to achieve its ambitious goals, by nature EGD is a soft law, a series of notices, guidelines and or communications that are not binding but enshrined as a duty of the member states to achieve the cooperation. EGD's communications support the 'green oath: do no harm' in accordance with fair transition, but the commission's do no harm agenda is vague and there is difficulty in tracking its enforceability in varying country contexts (Sikora, 2020). 1) Climate targets for 2030 and 2050 with a stronger focus on carbon pricing; 2) Green, affordable, and secure energy sources; 3) Circular economy development in tandem with industrial strategy; 4) Smart and sustainable mobility programs; 5) Common agricultural policy/Farm Fork Strategy; 6) Preservation of Biodiversity and Zero Pollution aspirations; 7) European Climate Pact and placing EU as the global leader to do so; are some of the parts of the EGD strategic framework. The framework demonstrates a strong interdependence between market mechanisms with an annual investment of 260 billion euros (approximately about 1.5% of the EU

GDP), however, establishes a weak link to its global mandate for resource extraction, international investment partnerships, and carbon tariff agreements (Vela Almeida et al., 2023).

The inception of EGD in 2019 has been the result of a long climate diplomacy, from the initial pledge of 8% emission reduction during the Kyoto Protocol (2008-2012), to 20% and 40% emission reduction by 2020 and 2030, as well as another increase in the 2020 target to reach a 55% emission reduction by 2030 (compared to 1990s level) (Skjærseth, 2021). The policies and programs enshrined within EGD covers all facets of economic dimensions, however, the article focuses mainly on two conflict-related issues that are commonly brought up under the EGD's just and inclusive transition: *resource extraction* and the *social hazards related to the green transition*. The European Commission (2020) predicts that by 2050, the demand for essential elements like cobalt, graphite, and lithium—driven by e-mobility and renewable energy—will significantly outstrip present EU consumption, rising by four to five times for cobalt, six to seven times for graphite, and twenty times for lithium. For instance, half of the world's cobalt consumption is linked to electric vehicles production highlighting that the EU's dependence on raw materials produced outside its borders (Sabato & Fronteddu, 2020). This reliance exacerbates global inequalities, as countries with low carbon footprints are held to the same standards as those with higher emissions, and the EU's carbon neutrality commitments place disproportionate burdens on the most vulnerable populations (Nae & Panie, 2024).

“The greening of capitalism does not destroy the old capitalism” ~ Ossewaarde and Ossewaarde-Lowtoo (2020)

In Perception: Green Growth and Competition as Social Fixes

The perception that economic growth and technological solutions can serve as 'social fixes' to the environmental crisis is central to the EGD rationale. Terms like 'sustainable finance' and 'competitive sustainability' are often used to legitimize market competition and rationalize the need for financial investments, but they do so by overlooking the broader social risks that accompany these approaches (Sikora, 2020). Although EGD highlights the necessity of industrial transformation to achieve carbon neutrality, its content is unclear and mostly concentrates on technological solutionism, which holds that the continent's continued technological advancement is the only option to resolve the ecological challenge. According to Ossewaarde and Ossewaarde-Lowtoo (2020), technological innovation may be essential to the green transition, but it also carries a number of ecological and social risks that hasten environmental degradation. According to Čavoški (2022) and Hereu-Morales et al. (2024), tech companies continue to hold a significant hegemonic stakeholder relationships in the EGD, their excessive reliance on fossil fuel industries implies that they are subject to corporate interests, competitiveness, and the continuation of green or brown capitalism. For example, the EU in 2018 remains the largest subsidizers of fossil fuels in the world by spending €159 billion, which is a stark contradiction to their climate neutrality rhetoric where one third of the money went into supporting oil and gas giants in forms of grants, tax incentives, price supports or loans (Hedberg, 2021). Between 2016 and 2020, \$635 billion was

financed by EU-based banks for the most polluting types of fossil fuel development and extraction (Engström et al., 2021).

The ‘win-win’ scenario where economic growth is decoupled from either ecological or social impact as perceived by the EGD is an archaic concept because this notion has remained in place for decades but has not been able to stop the accelerated environmental degradation (Vela Almeida et al., 2023). The neo-liberal philosophy of the 1990s ‘green economy’ and the current ‘green transition’ shares similar ethos. Sustainable financing has failed to uphold the \$100 billion commitment made at COP21 in Paris, while national and regional stakeholders continue to use their regulatory power to reinforce the idea that financing for the green transition is limited. As a result, EGD is encouraged to move toward portfolios that are more profit and growth driven (Vela Almeida et al., 2023). Moreover, backing climate policy is only appealing if it benefits the prevailing economic interests such as investing in export industries and private funding (Kupzok & Nahm, n.d.). The EU growth mandate, founded on extractive and intrinsic economic development, ignores or fails to acknowledge the cumulative pressures on ecosystems and societal obligations (Vezzoni, 2023).

Decarbonization, clean energy, and expansion in production and consumption are some of the specific growth areas that are the focus of the EGD-related initiatives but consistently overlooks persisting inequalities, poverty, hunger, justice and decent work among many others. These areas of social risks are not considered because decision makers even at the EU level prioritize methods that are simple and flexible to apply and that provide actionable results (Koundouri et al., 2024). Devising social instruments to address these risks does not provide immediate profit incentives, is

not tangible, at least unlike economic growth and outcome can only be visible in the long term. EGD will not be able to establish itself as an aspiring model by only focusing on achieving climate neutrality when socio-ecological sustainability and justice components are largely missing. Even if climate neutrality were to be reached by transforming our industries, it can be debated at what cost if social inequality, conflicts, job losses, and the burden on the weakest members of society continue to exist. Technically speaking EGD diminishes the concept of climate neutrality (a condition in which climate systems are not significantly impacted by human activity) to carbon neutrality (anthropogenic carbon removals, such as net zero GHG emissions) leaving room for conjecture that the agreement is shortsighted rather than long-term. Comparably, EGD demonstrates its commitment to making the raw material extraction process more transparent and sustainable, but no methods have been outlined to accomplish this, leaving many gaps in perception and the understanding of the EGD ([Hereu-Morales et al., 2024](#)).

“It is clear that tomorrow’s society cannot be concentrated on growth, at least not as far as material goods are concerned” ~ Sicco Mansholt 1972 from (Laurent, 2020).

In Practice: The EGD as Growth Continuity, Not Transformation

Are EGD’s policies in practice novel or simply a continuation of the green growth discourse?

In contrast to previous EC commitments, such as those made under Juncker and Barroso, who both overlooked environmental protection, EGD is novel as it is a more thorough and detailed strategy that expressly commits to a green economy Čavoški (2022). EGD implicitly communicates to increase GDP while reducing GHG emission and hence decouple emissions with economic growth but the question of how genuine this decoupling remains unanswered. Laurent (2020) gives evidence that EU member states between 1990 and 2018 were able to reduce GHGs emissions by 23% keeping the growth rate at 61% but this accounting is based on the calculation of GHGs produced within the EU borders only without accounting for the consumption emissions. To put it differently, if there is a transfer and addition of the consumption emission to the production emissions then the EU emission reduction from 1990 to 2017 is no longer 21% but rather 5%. While the commission solidifies its commitment to fight against climate change 75% of the proclaimed EU climate performance to reduce GHGs emission vanishes in such calculation tricks. One could argue that EGD's emergence in the midst of many crises, including a worsening ecological crisis, economic disparities, escalating social crises that is fueling a right-wing resurgence, is another novelty (Haas et al., 2022). While the EGD acknowledges the widening

economic and social inequalities, it does not produce radical solutions to address them, the fact that EGD emerged during multiple crises does not make it inherently novel as crises serve as catalyst for policy changes not implying its revolutionary characteristics.

Green growth is more conventional and economic in its direction, with material well-being as its primary focus, while maintaining its oligarchical power structures, the EGD with similar characteristics is the continuation of the green growth discourse. The EU's green growth rhetoric has appeared in a number of settings, including the global financial crisis from 2007 to 2009, the European Debt Crisis from 2009 to 2014, and the Europe 2020 Strategy (2010) ([Ossewaarde & Ossewaarde-Lowtoo, 2020](#)). The green growth discourse frames the protection of environment as a high investment return initiative (with products such as wind, solar energy) which can create economization (subsidies, job creation, green innovation). This way of doing directly relates to the necessity of greening the EU economy not for the sole purpose of protecting the environment but for conducive growth. Infinite growth on a finite planet is impossible, and this approach fails to address the root causes of ecological crises. In their paper, [Ossewaarde & Ossewaarde-Lowtoo \(2020\)](#) give examples of green growth discourse as a product of the capitalistic political and economic establishment, which sees environmental protection as a new branding disguised in old agendas. For example, even though they continue to dominate the fossil fuel sectors, big energy firms like Royal Dutch Shell are portrayed as the leaders of the green revolution. Similar to the Green Deal's central tenet, the EGD has a strong emphasis on strict calculations, percentages reductions but limited focus on improving the social dimension or shaping revolutionary ways of living or thinking to reduce emissions. EGD adheres to the green growth logic, which aims to solve climate change with new green technology (EVs and renewable energy (mix of green and brown

energy)) without lowering economic growth or middle-class living standards (Ossewaarde & Ossewaarde-Lowtoo, 2020; Čavoški, 2022; Pollin, 2019). The 350 billion euros that will be invested in green technology over the next ten years—more than in the previous decade—is predicated on the idea that technological advancement will automatically address ecological issues without considering social hazards, changes in lifestyle, or growth itself. This is supported by the EU's Sustainable Europe Investment Plan, which redirects investments from fossil fuels to renewables and opens new markets for climate-neutral goods like steel and cement. One of the many questions it raises: are such ambitions even achievable? Can carbon neutrality be achieved without radically changing our fixation on growth? Many scholarly papers used as reference for this study point out that, there needs to be a proper understanding of what prosperity entails, and a need for systemic transformation of economic, social and political systems – the current trajectory of EGD is not enough as it reinforces the status quo of green growth rather than challenging it.

“The project lacks a substantial definition of a just transition for people (and not companies)” ~ (Laurent, 2020).

Can the Just Transition Fund (JTF) and Social Climate Fund (SCF) address the needs of a just transition?

EGD outlines three instruments dedicated to transition through Just Transition Mechanism (JTM), the Invest EU program and one of the pillars within JTM is the JTF. The JTF aims to mobilize capital to ease the socio-economic impact of green transition to the most affected regions. Although the 19.2 billion allocation between 2021 and 2027 is an impressive accomplishment, a

closer examination reveals that the fund includes areas that rely heavily on the production of fossil fuels, namely coal (Laurent, 2020). There might be justification for the phase-out of coal, however this industry is rather minuscule in comparison to more diverse and dispersed industries like electric vehicles, agriculture, and housing. Again, associated climate disasters for instance, heatwaves kill the poor more frequently than the wealthy, those who can afford to invest in adaptation and resilience are not much affected and thus widening the gap between the insured and uninsured. The EGD is ill-equipped to handle these inequalities (Gaventa, 2019). The so-called ‘transition’ initiatives promote a status quo-style just transition by primarily focusing on growth potential agendas with lacking social component. JTM, which is supposed to be a novel approach, is essentially an economic tool that stresses ‘productive’ policy (ALMPs) by emphasizing job creation and regional development through active labor market involvement. Bypassing structural inequalities in class, gender, and race, EGD only serves those who can directly contribute to economic growth, leaving out a wide range of vulnerable communities, including indigenous groups, women and disabled who are unable to contribute to the growth strategy. Energy poverty and other deprivation concerns are also approached from a productive outlook (Zimmermann & Gengnagel, 2023; Haas et al., 2022).

Additionally, the SCF a part of EU fit for 55 package, boasts an additional funding of 86.7 billion from 2026 to 2032 to support member states to address the social impacts of green transition and facilitate the most vulnerable in households, micro-enterprises and mobility sectors. The added complexity is that the SCF only comes into action in 2026, but the climate conflicts are already in motion and a concern. Both the JTF and SCF are constrained in financing, time frame, sectors, activities and measures they try to change which are merely reactionary only responding to urgent

issues and failing to solve the long-term issues. Like the guiding principle of EGD, just transition mechanisms in both JTF and SCF do not pertain legal obligations to support the workers or the communities, and member states are free to choose which risks from the funds are invested rather than used to protect the most vulnerable (workers and/or communities) (Laurent, 2020). Without creating concrete strategies/ways for bringing along the people most affected by the transition, the EGD only anticipates a profound industrial transformation and envisions achieving just transition through ‘leave no one behind’ narratives – again bringing back the focus of limited bargaining power and participation of the most affected in this process.

“While the global community congratulates itself on achieving what is politically possible, we cannot overlook the anemic nature of the agreement considering the magnitude of the problem. It will not avoid the death of millions – because they simply do not matter.”

~ (Sultana, 2022)

In Communication: moral justifications for burden-shifting, climate protection rhetoric vs reality

Fleming and Mauger (2021) raise an interesting issue of rhetorics in communicating the goals and results of the EGD for carbon reduction. For example EU currently faces the gap to achieve 55% overall reduction by 2030 and it might only be able to bring it down to 47%, even if it does, the 8% emission is unaccounted for, the EGD’s communication translates as “we do not know where

exactly the additional 8% emission reductions are supposed to come from, but we will find something somewhere in our laws, don't worry" (p.169). This approach erodes trust of the public and related stakeholders, and it risks itself being perceived as unprepared or insincere that can fuel social unrest and skepticism at large. Additionally, the ambiguity in communicating the implementation plans may lead to ad hoc measures placing burden disproportionately among vulnerable groups and regions the most. For instance, such as last-minute resort to fulfill the climate targets result in harsher cost on lower income communities or industries. The pomposity of 'finding something somewhere' justify the sacrifice of certain groups without properly addressing the root causes of inequality and thus perpetuating social risks under the guise of necessity.

The EU's quest to portray itself positively following decades of catastrophes like the Euro-crisis, the refugee and migrant crisis, Brexit, and other existential threats is the pinnacle of self-justification. Embracing climate change issues fits the European climate agenda, fits amongst younger voters and looks superior communicating itself as the first climate neutral continent reaching zero emissions by 2050 (van der Sluis, 2023). Therefore, to achieve this goal, the EGD must demonstrate observable outcomes, numbers that translate to climate targets, outcomes that emphasizes market integration, economic efficiency, and fostering technological innovation - however devolving the social risks doesn't quite match the prestige as the one that establishes EU as the first carbon neutral region in the world.

‘Unintended consequences’ as a communicative rhetoric to deflect accountability?

Strong opposition and social unrest have occurred that run counter to the EGD. For example, in 2018, the French gilets jaunes (yellow vest) movement erupted as protests among the middle class and poor, who claimed that the cost of climate policies was directly borne by them in the form of higher fuel prices (Hafner & Raimondi, 2020). The EGD insists that the transition to carbon neutrality is ‘just and inclusive’ by putting people at the forefront, paying attention to regional inequalities and addressing the challenges that workers face. However, the ‘green transition’ policy and ‘just and inclusive’ policies are incompatible since the ‘just’ policies are too disjointed, too limited, and do not impose any legal requirements or guarantee that no one is left behind (Laurent, 2020). The EGD's decarbonization effect will mostly impact the energy and automotive sectors, affecting over 14 million employment. However, the process of creating and losing jobs is not uniform, and moving employees to green jobs is not always simple as made believed by the deal. In the same way, low-income households will be disproportionately impacted by the EU's Emission Trading Schemes due to their lack of initial resources to jump start the switch to green appliances. The unintended are always the low-income groups, migratory workers, the elderly, and those with impairments (Akgüç et al., 2022). This raises an important question whether EGD treats them as collaterals that need to be shed to pave way for a greener economy.

Laurent (2020), postulates that the tensions reflected in the EGD are far-reaching beyond its borders. The morphism of the just and inclusive outcomes proclaimed comes at the cost of substantial extraction of raw resources needed to achieve the EU's digital and low-carbon economy, including copper, lithium, and other rare earth elements. The resources are extracted from the

global south at the expense of growing social and environmental effects. In essence, this is basically shifting the burdens from the EU zone to the most vulnerable resource peripheries in the global south, while it takes place elsewhere the communication is silenced in official discourses. EGD acknowledges the resource requirement to fuel their green transition and underlines policies to green the value chain, improve social and environmental due diligence – all these only come from a reactionary point of view, EGD as a whole disregards the assessment of the deal's moral traits and how these harms are caused by the EGD's design, which emphasizes green growth (da Silva Hyldmo et al., 2024). To make matters even bleak, (Zimmermann & Gengnagel, 2023) highlight that there is no mention of ecological debt that the north owes to the south in the EGD, the supply of resources from the global south is justified based on the security need of the EU industries ignoring the fact that much of the prosperity that EU enjoys historically and today comes from the resource exploitation and deaths of vulnerable people in the global south.

Based on these scholarly evidence, I raise the question: To whom is the transition truly just? Who is it meant to be inclusive for? Is it only the EU regions that are the focus, while the ultra-poor in the global south are left to bear the costs themselves against the EU-driven vision of a carbon-neutral continent? Shouldn't the principles of 'do no harm', 'leave no one behind', and a 'just transition' apply universally—whether someone lives in Geneva, the slums of Bangladesh, or mines in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)? Shouldn't the commitment to justice and inclusivity in the green transition extend beyond the borders of the EU and address global inequalities?

“We cannot adapt to starvation. We cannot adapt to extinction. We cannot eat coal. We cannot drink oil. We will not give up.” ~

Venessa Nakate COP 26

The realities of mineral extractivism and the perpetrated social risks in global south regions: Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)

The green transition postulated by the EGD and its race to net-zero is a highly mineral intensive and the EU demand for minerals such as copper, graphite, manganese, nickel and platinum, all such rare earth minerals is expected to rise to 6 folds by 2030 and 11 to 14-fold by 2050. The demand for lithium is to increase exceptionally, 12 folds by 2030 and 90-fold by 2050. As of 2022, DRC accounted for 70% of the world's greatest supply of cobalt, which is used in a variety of green technologies. Although the EU presently purchases most its rare earth minerals from China, it is looking for ways to reduce its reliance on the country due to geopolitical vagaries (Findeisen, n.d.). If the EU were to fully reduce their dependency on China, then that would mean 90% of their demand (until it becomes self-sufficient) transfers to the global south nations such as the DRC. As of March 2023, the EU commission has proposed the Critical Raw Materials Act signing agreements between DRC and Zambia in order to ensure a varied, reasonably priced, and sustainable supply of raw materials (Neema, 2024). Despite having just 6% of the world's population, the EU consumes 25–30% of the metals produced globally, and it has been estimated that 10% of global energy-related emissions in 2018 came from the production and extraction of minerals (Bolger et al., n.d.). In my understanding of the resource extraction in line with EGD

there is a feedback loop where one action (EU's push for carbon neutrality) feeds back into the system (resource extractivism) and creation of a cyclic effect (increase in emissions in return)

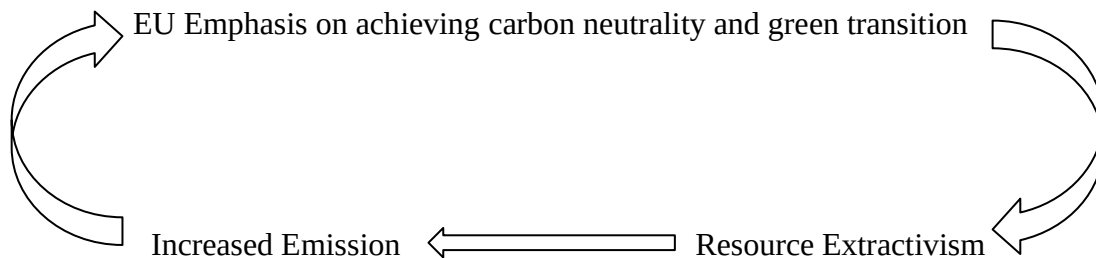


Figure 1: EGD feedback loop on resource-emission relation

The absence of critical assessment of the over consumption, production and distribution patterns of the EU need realization rather than increasing extractive missions in the global south. While EGD expresses the ‘sustainability’ rhetoric in its communication for mining of the rare earth minerals, the societal and environmental standards are barely met. Mining has grave social risks associated with it such as artisanal miners face intimidation, human rights violation, sexual exploitation, child labor, human trafficking and or living in extreme economic hardship – all of which is an everyday reality in DRC. While the vulnerable population lives in such dreads, the Congolese mines have been the center of Euro centric hubs of consumption, electrification and profits for multinational companies (Bolger et al., n.d.). Historical records suggest that DRC has sold 329,000 tons of copper to primarily European countries since gaining independence in the 1960s; at the present time, the trade has expanded to America and Asia. A century of mining in the Congo has resulted in enormous waste heaps, acid spills, a dearth of flora, a devastated aquatic habitat, and other environmental problems (Peša, 2022). Unequal vulnerabilities, marginalization, fatalities, and destruction of ecosystems and communities are all manifestations of the slow

violence that has endured for generations (Sultana, 2022). In the Congo, social injustices and environmental harm are accepted as ‘collateral damage’ (Peša, 2022).

For hundreds of years, native communities have been ‘othered’ and labeled as ‘uncivilized’ to be exploited, uprooted, and created sacrifice zones and/or sacrifice people for the economic and social prosperity of the north which has been studied extensively through the lenses of colonial-capitalistic extractivism and commodification. With the new growth agreements like the EGD, ecological destruction is being rebranded with rhetoric like ‘we are all in the same boat’ and ‘fighting climate change requires a collective effort’ (Sultana, 2022; Vela Almeida et al., 2023). It can be concluded that populations in these green sacrifice zones are displaced not by climate change itself, but rather by regional/governmental decisions to cause it in the name of greater good (Urvás, 2023). This is a way to perceive, communicate and replicate policies, ignoring historical injustices and ignoring the past.

Conclusion

The EGD aims in separating economic growth from resource usages to transform the EU economy in a more fair, competitive, carbon-neutral and sustainable way. However, the communication of EGD decoupling economic growth from environmental impact is initially perplexing; is this ever going to be accomplished? And second - it frames to use the environmental challenges as an opportunity to invest in green technology to become the first carbon neutral region in the world by 2050 without compromising its economic stability but paying little attention to solving social risks. With increasing scientific evidence of the anthropogenic climate change related disasters across

the globe having an ambitious goal such as the EGD is a necessity correcting the previous ‘wait-and-see’ attitudes and decade long silence in addressing climate related issues, yet its approach reveals significant contradictions and shortcomings in framing as (Urvias, 2023) outlines “a deal on whose terms”? (p.38). But also, in terms of perception where EGD appears to justify the acceleration of economic growth and green technology as automatic social remedies, in reality, it only expands on earlier growth deals without seeking to address social issues associated with the shift to a green economy. Even if it does so through a fair transition mechanism, its insurance is not comprehensive and does not help everyone who needs it. Lastly, in communication, EGD silences the capitalistic-colonial extractivism forced on the most vulnerable in the global south while presenting itself favorably as a region that was the ‘first to take action’ against climate change.

To support market-driven solutions, EGD place an undue emphasis on economic measures, systemic transformation is more important than technology solutionism which is believed to address the fallout of vulnerable groups from the transition. While vital, the emphasis on industry and technology ignores the ecological and social risks associated with these advancements. It is neither revolutionary nor a champion deal because the resources needed to address social risks are fragmented or insufficient, unlike those allocated for financial derisking and/or for geopolitical stability. Instead, it is more akin to the green economy of the 1990s or business as usual because addressing social risks does not result in immediate financial gain, is not readily apparent, and has long-term implications that make it less appealing than economic growth. The EGD's vision of a green transition is thus yet incomplete.

EGD's communication and implementation further highlight its inadequacies with ambiguity around emission reduction targets, such as the unaccounted 8% gap by 2030, erodes public trust and raises concerns about the feasibility of its goals. The JTF and SCF, while significant, are narrowly focused, experiencing budget cuts and insufficient to address the wide-ranging social impacts of the transition. These mechanisms prioritize economic growth and job creation over social protection, leaving vulnerable groups—such as low-income households, migrant workers, and indigenous communities—exposed to disproportionate burdens. The EGD's rhetoric of inclusivity and justice is contradicted by its practice of shifting ecological burdens onto the global south, as seen in the case of mineral extraction in the DRC. The reliance on resources perpetuates colonial-capitalist exploitation, creating sacrifice zones where environmental degradation and social inequalities are accepted as collateral damage. This disconnects between the EGD's moral justifications, and its real-world impacts undermines its credibility and raises questions about its commitment to a truly just and inclusive transition. Can we be satisfied with the underplay of 'just and inclusive' but only for those who live 'here' (EU region) and not 'there' (global south).

While the aim of the paper is not to denounce European determinations to green transitions, but to contextualize the need for a more holistic outlook for its development efforts. Taking into considerations not only economic, technological and geo-political relations but also the need to address social risks and contextualize colonial-capitalist relations. EGD's ambition to achieve climate neutrality is commendable, the way our world is accelerating towards rising global temperature, it is not only visionary but rather a necessary deal to keep us on track. Despite this EGD is still rather short term with its 2050 mark, it falls short of its execution efforts in addressing the systemic social challenges for a genuine transformation. The deal's continuation of green

growth discourse, coupled with its inadequate attention to social equity and ecological justice, highlights the need for a more radical rethinking of growth, equity, and sustainability. EGD of such caliber and ambition must go beyond market-driven solutions and adopt a more comprehensive strategy that places a higher priority on social justice, ecological integrity, and systemic change. It must also commit to specific actions to hold corporate, political, and other actors accountable. This includes addressing the ethical implications of resource extraction, ensuring equitable distribution of transition costs, and fostering inclusive decision-making processes. Without these fundamental changes, the EGD risks becoming another neoliberal policy that prioritizes economic growth over the well-being of people and the planet, leaving its promise of a just and sustainable future unfulfilled.

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